



The Xero Integration Playbook

How a bookkeeping practice gets premium-tier results from Xero — without premium-tier prices or premium-tier hours

SkillForge AI Playbook Series — Xero Integration Edition

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A note from Bill

I spent 32 years in the computer industry before I started writing these playbooks. I designed cloud solutions for Fortune 500 companies, and here's what I learned: the software is almost never the whole answer. The answer is the workflow you wrap around it.

Xero is good software. But every bookkeeper reading this knows its edges — the tiers that gate the features you actually want, the support that isn't there when the bank feed breaks at 4 PM on a Friday, the reports that won't bend the way your clients need. This playbook doesn't fix Xero. It fixes what you do *around* Xero.

Every chapter ends with something you can use the same day: a prompt to copy and paste, a checklist to run, a script to send. No theory. No homework.

One caution before you start. AI reads numbers fast, but it doesn't know your client's tax position, their state rules, or what's actually legal on a filing. Anywhere compliance or taxes come up, you'll see "CPA or attorney verifies this" notes. That's deliberate. And you'll see client-data privacy notes throughout — other people's money means other people's secrets. Guard them like your practice depends on it, because it does.

Let's get to work.

— Bill



How to use this playbook

Read it front to back once, or jump straight to the chapter that hurts most. Each chapter stands alone. The copy-paste prompts are marked like this:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT: The prompt text goes here, with [BRACKETS] showing where you fill in your details.

When you see **[EXAMPLE]**, that's a made-up illustration to show you how something looks finished — not a real client, not a real practice, not real numbers. Anything presented as fact is something you can verify yourself.

You don't need to change anything about your Xero setup to start. Chapter 2 covers the only AI subscriptions worth paying for — and the whole book works whether your clients are on Xero's cheapest plan or its most expensive one. That's the point.

A note on Xero's own AI: Xero ships features under names like "Just Ask Xero." Those are fine. This book is not about those features. It's about what *you* do with a general AI chatbot wrapped around Xero — the onboarding, the cleanup, the close, the reports, the triage, the advisory. The workflows no software button gives you.

CHAPTER 1**Where a Xero practice is leaking money**

Before we talk about AI, let's talk about the leaks. Not the client's money — yours. The hours you spend on work you can't bill, or can only bill at rates that don't cover the tedium.

There are four of them, and every bookkeeper or small-firm owner running clients on Xero will recognize all four.

Leak #1: Onboarding that eats a month

New client signs up. Then the slow drip begins: chasing last year's books, the shoebox of receipts, the chart of accounts that doesn't match anything, the third "one more thing" email about how they do invoicing. You quoted onboarding as a week. It's week three and you're still categorizing.

The pain isn't the work — it's that it's unbillable-feeling work. The client already mentally spent the onboarding fee in week one. Everything after that is you subsidizing their disorganization.

Leak #2: Cleanup jobs that grow

"Can you just take a quick look at our books?" It's never quick. The bank feed broke four months ago and nobody noticed. There are 300 unreconciled lines. Someone categorized loan payments as expenses. You quoted four hours. It's hour nine and you're in the weeds.

Cleanup is the most common work in small practices and the hardest to price, because the mess is always bigger than the client described. You either eat the overage or have an awkward conversation.

Leak #3: Month-end that takes the month

The close should be a few days of review. Instead it's two weeks of chasing missing statements, re-running reports, fixing the same categorization mistakes, and writing the same "here's your P&L" email twelve different ways. By the time the numbers go out, they're stale. The client glances at them and asks, "So... are we okay?" — and you realize the close produced numbers but no insight.

Leak #4: The support black hole

The bank feed stops syncing. A payroll line won't reconcile. Something's off in the sales tax return and the deadline is Friday. You need Xero support. There is no phone number. You submit a ticket, wait, and refresh. Your client is asking you questions you can't answer yet. You're stuck between a client who needs certainty and a vendor who answers when it answers.

What these four leaks have in common



None of them is a bookkeeping-knowledge problem. You know the debits and credits. All four are *throughput* problems — intake, sorting, reviewing, explaining, waiting. And throughput is exactly what AI is good at.

That's the whole thesis of this playbook: point AI at the four leaks, and your practice gets faster without getting sloppier. Same judgment. More capacity. And the capacity turns into the thing most practices never have time for: advisory work, which is where the real margins live. Chapter 8 gets you there.

Your same-day action: Before you read Chapter 2, do this 10-minute audit. Grab a notepad and answer honestly:

- 1.** How long did your last three client onboardings *actually* take, versus what you quoted?
- 2.** What percentage of your month-end hours is chasing documents and fixing categorization, versus actual review and judgment?
- 3.** How many hours last month did you spend stuck waiting on something outside your control — a bank feed, a support ticket, a client who won't send the missing statement?

You don't need to show this to anyone. It's your "before" picture. In Chapter 9, you'll take the "after."

CHAPTER 2**Your AI stack — what to buy, what to skip**

This chapter saves you the most money in this book, because the AI industry would love to sell your practice twelve subscriptions. Here's the truth for a bookkeeping practice running clients on Xero: you need two things. Everything else is optional, and most of it you should skip.

What to buy #1: One chatbot subscription (paid tier)

This is the workhorse. One paid subscription to a general AI chatbot — the kind where you type or talk and it writes, analyzes, and summarizes. This single tool powers Chapters 3 through 9: onboarding documents, cleanup triage, close checklists, variance narratives, custom reports, support triage, and advisory drafts.

Which one? The two established options are ChatGPT (paid tier) and Claude (paid tier). Either one does everything in this book. Pick one based on which interface you find easier — both offer free tiers to try first. You need only one; buying both is the first waste of money this chapter prevents.

Set it up in 20 minutes:

1. Create the account with your *practice* email, not a personal one — and enable two-factor authentication. This account will touch client financial data. Treat it like it has the keys to the office.
2. Turn on whatever "memory" or "custom instructions" feature it offers, and enter the following. This teaches it who you are so you stop re-explaining yourself in every prompt:

`COPY-PASTE – PRACTICE PROFILE (paste into the chatbot's custom instructions or memory): I run a bookkeeping practice. My clients use Xero. I am not a CPA and this account is not used for final tax or legal determinations – everything compliance-related gets verified by the client's CPA or attorney. Write everything at a plain-business reading level. Never invent tax code sections, filing deadlines, or regulatory requirements – if I need those, I will look them up or ask the client's CPA. Treat all client data as confidential; never retain client names or account numbers in examples. Flag anything that looks like a compliance or tax-filing decision and remind me to have it verified.`

3. That's it. Every prompt in this book now works better because the chatbot knows your practice.

What to buy #2: An AI document-capture workflow

This plugs Leak #1 and Leak #2 directly. Client documents — receipts, invoices, statements — arrive as photos, PDFs, and email attachments. An AI capture tool reads them and extracts the vendor, date, amount, and line items into structured data you can review before it touches Xero.

A few honest notes before you buy:



- **This is a category, not a single product.** Multiple tools do this (several built specifically for bookkeepers, several general-purpose). Many integrate directly with Xero.
- **You review everything before it posts.** This is a data-entry accelerator, not a bookkeeper replacement. AI reads a receipt faster than you; you still decide the account. The workflow is: capture → AI extracts → you review the exceptions → post. Never auto-post AI-extracted data to a client's books without human review. That's not efficiency, that's malpractice.
- **Trial it on one client for a month.** Measure: minutes per document before, minutes per document after. If it doesn't cut the time at least in half, try a different tool before committing.
- **Tell clients what it is.** "We use AI-assisted document capture, and every item is reviewed by a human before it hits your books." Clients like hearing this. It sounds like what it is: modern and careful.

What to skip

- **"AI bookkeeping platforms" that want to replace Xero.** You don't need a new general ledger. You need AI *around* the one your clients already use. Ripping out Xero for an AI-branded ledger is the most expensive way to learn that lesson.
- **Multiple chatbot subscriptions.** One is enough. They overlap almost completely.
- **AI "tax advice" or "compliance autopilot" tools.** Anything that promises to make filing decisions for you is a liability with a subscription fee. Your judgment plus the client's CPA is the compliance stack. AI drafts; humans sign.
- **Premium Xero tiers bought for features AI can replicate.** Read Chapter 6 before you upgrade any client's plan — you may be able to deliver the *outcome* of the expensive tier on the cheap one.

The client-data privacy rules (memorize these)

Because this chapter puts AI next to other people's money:

1. **Anonymize before you paste.** Strip client names, account numbers, and tax IDs from anything you paste into a chatbot. "Client A" is fine. Real names are not.
2. **Know your tool's data policy.** Use the business/paid tier with data-retention controls; turn off any "use my data to train models" setting. If you can't find the setting, ask the vendor in writing before client data goes in.
3. **Tell clients in your engagement letter.** One sentence: "We use AI-assisted tools for document processing and analysis; all client data is handled under our confidentiality obligations and reviewed by a human." Your attorney can wordsmith it. (That's a "have your attorney verify this" note — see, we're already practicing.)
4. **Never paste full bank statements with account numbers.** Export the transaction *lines* you need, strip identifiers, then analyze.



These four rules cost you nothing and protect everything. Every chapter from here assumes you're following them.

Your same-day action: Set up the chatbot subscription with the practice profile above, and check its data-retention settings. That's your foundation. Everything else in this book plugs into it.

CHAPTER 3

Client onboarding in days, not weeks

Onboarding is where practices lose money they never bill. The fix isn't rushing — it's front-loading. AI lets you build the entire onboarding kit *before* the kickoff call, so the client walks into a process instead of a questionnaire.

The 48-hour onboarding kit

Within 48 hours of a signed engagement, produce four things. Each one takes minutes with AI and used to take an afternoon.

1. The document request list. Every client needs to hand over the same categories of records, but the specifics differ by business type. Prompt:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – tailored document request list: I am onboarding a new bookkeeping client. Business type: [TYPE, e.g. residential plumbing company, 8 employees]. They use Xero on the [PLAN TIER] plan. Their prior bookkeeping was [PRIOR STATE, e.g. spreadsheets, another accountant, nothing]. Generate a document request list organized by category: (1) business formation and tax documents, (2) prior-period financial records, (3) banking and credit accounts, (4) payroll records, (5) recurring bills and contracts, (6) revenue sources and invoicing. For each item, include: what it is in plain language, acceptable formats, and why we need it. End with a "send what you have by [DATE]" instruction and a note that partial submissions are fine – send what's ready.

2. The chart-of-accounts mapping. The client's old categories never match your standard chart. Instead of manually mapping 80 accounts, paste the old list (anonymized) and prompt:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – chart-of-accounts mapping: Map the following legacy account names to a standard small-business chart of accounts suitable for Xero. For each legacy account, give: the recommended Xero account name, the account type, and a one-line reason if the mapping isn't obvious. Flag any legacy account that looks like a personal expense mixed into business books, and list any legacy account you're unsure about separately with your best guess marked as uncertain. Legacy accounts: [PASTE LIST]

Review every line. AI is fast at the obvious mappings and honest about the uncertain ones — that's exactly the split you want, because the uncertain ones are where your judgment earns its fee.

3. The welcome pack. One page: how the relationship works, when the close happens each month, how to send documents, what you need by when, and what happens if documents are late. Prompt:



COPY-PASTE PROMPT – client welcome pack: Write a one-page client welcome pack for a bookkeeping practice. Tone: warm, professional, plain language. Sections: how we work together (monthly rhythm), how to send us documents (with the document-capture method), what we need from you by the 5th of each month, what happens if documents arrive late (stated kindly but clearly), how to reach us and expected response times, and one paragraph on confidentiality including our use of AI-assisted tools with human review. Business name: [PRACTICE NAME].

4. The kickoff call agenda. Fifteen minutes, structured. Prompt:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – kickoff agenda: Write a 15-minute kickoff call agenda for onboarding a new bookkeeping client on Xero. The document request list and welcome pack are already sent. Agenda should cover: confirming what they've sent vs. what's missing, Xero access and user roles, bank feed connections, payroll setup status, their invoicing workflow, and one question that surfaces how they actually run the business day-to-day. Include time blocks.

The "first 30 days" email sequence

Onboarding doesn't end at kickoff — it ends when the client has sent everything and the first clean close is done. Three check-in emails, pre-written:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – onboarding check-in emails: Write three short onboarding check-in emails for a bookkeeping client: (1) day 7 – friendly nudge on outstanding documents, listing the most commonly missing items; (2) day 14 – firmer, with a plain-language explanation of how missing documents delay their financials; (3) day 21 – final notice before we pause onboarding work, kind but explicit that the timeline is in their hands now. Each under 150 words. Sign as [PRACTICE NAME].

[EXAMPLE] — what the day-7 email looks like (illustrative):

Hi [CLIENT FIRST NAME] – quick check-in on the documents list. The three items most people are still hunting down at this point are last year's full bank statements, the payroll summary from your previous provider, and any loan statements. Send what you have – partial is fine, and it lets us start mapping while you gather the rest. Thanks, [YOUR NAME], [PRACTICE NAME].

Pricing the onboarding so it stops hurting

Here's the uncomfortable truth this chapter enables: most practices underprice onboarding because it feels like admin. Once AI cuts the actual hours, price onboarding as a *product* — a fixed-fee "Xero setup and first clean month" package. The client gets a defined deliverable and a defined price. You get paid for the value, not punished for the hours.

Your same-day action: Build the onboarding kit for your next new client before the kickoff call — request list, account mapping, welcome pack, agenda. Time yourself. Compare it to your last onboarding. That's your new baseline.

CHAPTER 4**Books-cleanup workflows — taming the mess**

"Can you just take a quick look at our books?" The cleanup job is the most common engagement in small practices and the hardest to scope, because the mess is always bigger than the client described. AI doesn't clean the books for you — it *sizes* the mess in an hour so you can price it honestly and attack it in order.

Step 1: The one-hour triage

Before you quote, run triage. Export from Xero: the unreconciled bank lines, the aged receivables/payables, and the general ledger summary for the period. Anonymize, then prompt:

`COPY-PASTE PROMPT – cleanup triage: I am triaging a books-cleanup engagement. Here is anonymized data from the client's Xero export: [PASTE: unreconciled transaction count and date range, aged receivables total and oldest invoice age, aged payables total and oldest bill age, and any accounts with unusual balances]. Produce: (1) a severity rating for each area (clean / needs attention / urgent), (2) the three problems most likely hiding in this data, described in plain language, (3) an estimated hour range for cleanup assuming a bookkeeper reviews every AI suggestion, and (4) five questions I should ask the client before quoting. Do not invent transactions or balances – work only from what I pasted.`

That hour range is your quote foundation. Show the client the triage summary (plain language, no jargon) alongside your fixed fee. Clients accept cleanup fees far more readily when they can see the mess itemized — "300 unreconciled lines across 4 months" sells the work better than any pitch.

Step 2: Categorization review at speed

The bulk of cleanup is categorization: hundreds of lines that need the right account. The workflow is AI-assisted, human-decided:

1. Export the uncategorized/unreconciled lines for one month.
2. Paste in batches (anonymized) with this prompt:

`COPY-PASTE PROMPT – categorization review: Categorize each transaction below into one of these Xero account names: [PASTE YOUR STANDARD ACCOUNT LIST]. For each transaction give: date, description, amount, suggested account, and a confidence rating (high / medium / low). Put every low-confidence item in a separate "needs human review" list at the end with your best guess and why you're unsure. Business type: [TYPE]. Never invent transactions. If a description is ambiguous, mark it low-confidence rather than guessing. Transactions: [PASTE BATCH]`

3. You review the high-confidence suggestions in bulk (spot-check, don't re-do), and spend your real attention on the low-confidence list. That's the correct division of labor: AI does the obvious 80%, you do the judgment 20%.
4. Post to Xero yourself. AI suggests; you decide; Xero records.



The duplicate hunt. Duplicates are the silent killer in messy books — the same expense entered twice, once by bank feed and once manually. Prompt:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – duplicate detection: Review these transactions for likely duplicates: same or near-same amount, same or similar vendor description, within 7 days of each other. List each suspected pair with dates, amounts, descriptions, and why they look like duplicates. Do not delete or merge anything – this is a review list only. Transactions: [PASTE BATCH]

Step 3: The "what broke" narrative

When cleanup is done, the client deserves to know what was wrong — in language that makes them value the work and avoid repeating it. Prompt:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – cleanup summary for client: Write a one-page cleanup summary for a client in plain language. Facts: [PERIOD CLEANED, e.g. Jan–Jun], [NUMBER] transactions reviewed, [NUMBER] corrections made, top three issues found were [ISSUES]. Tone: professional, no blame, no jargon. Include: what we fixed, what was causing it (in terms of their habits, kindly), and three specific habits that will keep the books clean going forward. End with what clean books now make possible for them (faster decisions, easier tax time). Under 400 words.

[EXAMPLE] — excerpt (illustrative):

What we fixed: 214 transactions across January to June were reviewed; 61 needed corrections. The three patterns we found: (1) loan payments were being recorded as regular expenses, which overstated your costs; (2) the bank feed disconnected in March and about 90 transactions were never imported; (3) several personal purchases were mixed into the business card. None of this is unusual – it happens in most growing businesses. Going forward: (1) keep one card strictly for business, (2) tell us the same day a bank feed looks wrong, (3) send receipts weekly instead of monthly. Your books are now current through June, which means your next tax estimate will be based on real numbers instead of guesses.

The cleanup pricing rule

Quote cleanup fixed-fee from the triage hour range, with a clause: "If triage reveals the mess is materially larger than estimated, we re-quote before proceeding — you'll see the evidence first." AI triage makes this clause credible instead of scary, because you've already shown them the itemized mess.

Your same-day action: Run the triage prompt on your messiest current client (anonymized export). Even if you're mid-cleanup, the triage will surface anything you've missed and give you the client-facing summary for work already done.

CHAPTER 5

Month-end close acceleration — from two weeks to three days

The close has two halves: the mechanical half (chasing documents, reconciling, fixing) and the judgment half (review, variance, insight). AI devours the mechanical half. Your job is to protect the judgment half and stop doing the rest by hand.

The close checklist, generated fresh every month

Don't reuse last month's checklist from memory — generate it from this month's actual state:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – monthly close checklist: Generate a month-end close checklist for a bookkeeping client on Xero. Client: [BUSINESS TYPE], [NUMBER] bank/credit accounts, payroll [YES/NO, PROVIDER], inventory [YES/NO]. Current status: [WHAT'S DONE – e.g. bank feeds current through month-end, payroll posted, statements received for 2 of 3 accounts]. Organize as: (1) still missing – documents or data I need, with who owes each item; (2) reconciliation tasks in dependency order; (3) review tasks requiring human judgment; (4) client deliverables at the end. Mark each item as AI-assistable or human-only.

The "who owes each item" column is the secret weapon. Half of every slow close is not knowing what's missing versus what's merely not done. Send the missing-items list to the client on day 2 of the close — not day 9.

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – missing-documents email: Write a short email listing missing close documents for a client. Missing: [ITEMS]. For each, one plain-language line on why it matters to their financials. Tone: helpful, not scolding. Deadline: [DATE]. Under 150 words.

The AI review pass

Once reconciled, run the numbers past AI before you sign off. This is a second pair of eyes, not a second bookkeeper:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – pre-close review: Review this anonymized month-end data for a [BUSINESS TYPE]: [PASTE: P&L summary by account for the month, prior-month P&L for comparison, balance sheet summary, and aged receivables/payables totals]. Flag: (1) any account that moved more than [THRESHOLD, e.g. 20%] versus prior month, with the direction of the move; (2) any balance that looks wrong for this business type (e.g. negative asset, expense account with a credit balance); (3) receivables or payables aging in the wrong direction; (4) anything you'd want a human to look at before closing. Present as a review list with one-line explanations. Do not adjust any numbers – review only.

You investigate the flags. Most will have innocent explanations. The ones that don't are the errors that used to slip through — caught in minutes instead of discovered at tax time.

Variance narratives that write themselves (almost)



The client doesn't want a P&L. They want the answer to "are we okay?" Write the narrative with AI, verify every claim, send:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – monthly variance narrative: Write a plain-language monthly summary for a business owner who is not an accountant. Data: [PASTE ANONYMIZED: revenue, top 5 expense categories, net profit, cash balance – this month vs. prior month and vs. same month last year]. Structure: (1) the headline – one sentence on how the month went; (2) what changed and why, in plain language, no jargon; (3) cash position and what it means for the next 60 days; (4) one thing to watch. Under 300 words. No invented explanations – only describe what the numbers show; mark anything that needs the owner's context with [ASK OWNER].

[EXAMPLE] — excerpt (illustrative):

Headline: June was your strongest month this year – revenue up about 18% on May, and costs stayed flat, so most of that increase landed as profit. What changed: the two new maintenance contracts started billing, which is the bulk of the revenue lift. Cash position: the operating account ended June healthy, comfortably covering the next two months of payroll and rent at current burn. One thing to watch: materials costs crept up three months running – worth asking your supplier about before it becomes a trend. [ASK OWNER: the \$2,400 "miscellaneous" line in June – can you tell me what that was?]

The verification rule: read every AI-written narrative against the actual Xero reports before sending. AI describes numbers well and occasionally invents causes. Causes come from the owner or from you — never from the chatbot's imagination. The [ASK OWNER] flags are there to protect you; use them.

The 3-day close rhythm

Day 1: generate the checklist, send the missing-documents email, reconcile what's reconcilable. Day 2: chase stragglers, run the AI review pass, investigate flags. Day 3: write the variance narrative, verify, deliver. The close becomes a cadence instead of a crisis.

Your same-day action: Run the pre-close review prompt on last month's numbers for one client (anonymized). See what it flags. If it catches something you missed, you just proved the chapter's value to yourself.

CHAPTER 6**Champagne Xero on a beer budget — premium outcomes without premium prices**

This is the chapter the research pointed at. Xero gates its best features — multi-currency handling, project tracking, advanced reporting — behind its most expensive tiers. Many practices pay the upgrade because one client needs one gated feature. This chapter shows you how to deliver the *outcome* of those features with AI workflows on the cheaper plans.

The principle: the client doesn't want "multi-currency." They want to know what the overseas invoice actually cost them in home currency. They don't want "project tracking." They want to know whether the job made money. Sell the answer, not the feature.

Outcome 1: Multi-currency clarity without the multi-currency tier

Client invoices in euros, pays suppliers in dollars, reports in pounds. The expensive tier handles this natively. On a cheaper plan, the workflow is: export + AI.

COPY-PASTE PROMPT — foreign-currency exposure summary: I have anonymized invoice and bill data in multiple currencies. Home currency: [CURRENCY]. For each foreign-currency item, I will give you the amount, currency, issue date, and due/paid date. Using the approximate exchange rates I provide, produce: (1) every item restated in home currency, (2) total receivables and payables by currency, (3) the net exposure per currency — what we gain or lose if rates move 5% against us, and (4) a plain-language paragraph explaining the currency risk to a non-accountant business owner. Exchange rates: [RATES WITH DATES]. Do not invent rates — use only the ones I provide. Data: [PASTE ANONYMIZED ITEMS]

[EXAMPLE] — the plain-language paragraph (illustrative):

About a third of what clients owe you is in euros. At today's rate that's roughly £41,000. If the euro weakens 5% before those invoices are paid, you'd receive about £2,000 less in pounds — not because anyone did anything wrong, just because of the exchange rate moving. Two practical options: invoice the euro clients a little sooner, or talk to us about whether pricing in pounds makes sense going forward.

That's the advisory conversation the expensive tier was supposed to enable — delivered on the cheap plan, and frankly better, because it comes with your judgment attached.

Outcome 2: Project profitability without the projects tier

Trades, agencies, builders — they all ask "did that job make money?" Xero's answer lives behind a paywall. Yours lives in a tracking-category discipline plus AI.

The setup: use Xero tracking categories (if they're available and configured in the client's Xero organization) with one category per job or client project. Tag every invoice line and bill that belongs to the job. At month-end, export the P&L by tracking category and prompt:



COPY-PASTE PROMPT – job profitability review: Analyze this anonymized profit-and-loss by project. For each project give: revenue, direct costs, gross margin in amount and percent, and a one-line verdict (healthy / watch / losing money). Then: (1) rank projects by margin, (2) flag any project where costs are still being posted after the revenue stopped – that's usually missed billing, (3) identify the cost category dragging down the worst performer, and (4) write three plain-language questions I should ask the business owner about the bottom two projects. Data: [PASTE ANONYMIZED P&L BY TRACKING CATEGORY]

Run this monthly for project-based clients and you've replicated the headline feature of the expensive tier — plus the analysis Xero never gave you anyway.

Outcome 3: The reports Xero won't build

Xero's reporting is rigid — users say so consistently. The workaround is the same export-plus-AI pattern, pointed at whatever the client actually asks for:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – custom report builder: Build a custom report from this anonymized Xero export data. The business owner asked: "[THEIR QUESTION IN PLAIN LANGUAGE, e.g. which customers are actually profitable after support costs]". Available data: [DESCRIBE WHAT YOU EXPORTED]. Produce: (1) the answer in one paragraph of plain language, (2) a simple table showing the breakdown, (3) two caveats about what this data can't tell us, and (4) one follow-up question for the owner that would sharpen the answer. Data: [PASTE]

The two caveats are what make this professional instead of clever. AI will happily answer from incomplete data; your job is to say what the data *can't* prove. Clients trust the bookkeeper who says "here's what we know and here's what we'd need to be sure" far more than the one who overclaims.

The tier-audit habit

Once a quarter, audit every client's Xero plan against what they actually use. Prompt:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – subscription tier audit: Client: [BUSINESS TYPE]. Current Xero plan: [TIER]. Features they actually use each month: [LIST]. Features on their tier they never touch: [LIST]. Gated features they wish they had: [LIST]. Recommend: stay, downgrade, or upgrade – with the monthly savings or cost of each move, and which AI workflows from this playbook cover the gaps if they downgrade.

[EXAMPLE] — the kind of finding this produces (illustrative): a consultancy paying for the top tier solely for multi-currency invoicing, using nothing else gated. Downgrade saves them roughly the cost of the tier difference every month; the Chapter 6 currency workflow covers the one feature they needed. That's a conversation that pays for this playbook a hundred times over — and it's *your* advice, which is why they keep *you*.

Your same-day action: Run the tier audit on your three most expensive client subscriptions. If even one can downgrade, you've just handed a client a raise — and given yourself the best retention tool there is.



CHAPTER 7

AI triage — when there's no phone support

No phone support is the complaint that stings most, because it always arrives as an emergency: the bank feed broke, the reconciliation won't balance, payroll's wrong and people get paid Friday. You can't call anyone. So you build the triage muscle instead — diagnose in minutes, fix with confidence, and look unflappable doing it.

Triage 1: The broken bank feed

Symptoms: transactions stopped importing, duplicates appeared, or the feed shows an error. Before touching anything, gather facts — AI can't see your Xero screen, but it can reason from symptoms:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT — bank feed diagnosis: Diagnose a Xero bank feed problem from these symptoms. Bank: [BANK NAME]. Feed type: [DIRECT FEED / YODLEE-TYPE AGGREGATOR / MANUAL IMPORT]. Symptoms: [DESCRIBE — e.g. no new transactions since Tuesday, last successful import date, any error message verbatim]. Recent changes: [e.g. changed online banking password last week, bank did a system update, nothing changed]. Produce: (1) the three most likely causes in order, (2) for each cause, the exact check or fix to try first, in order, (3) what NOT to do — the common mistake that makes this worse (e.g. deleting and re-adding the feed and creating duplicates), and (4) at what point to escalate to Xero support with what information ready.

The "what NOT to do" section is the valuable part. The classic self-inflicted wound is deleting the feed connection and re-adding it, which imports months of duplicates. AI knows the failure patterns; you supply the judgment about which pattern matches.

[EXAMPLE] — a common diagnosis (illustrative): feed stopped Tuesday, client changed their online banking password Monday. Most likely cause: the aggregator's stored credentials expired. Fix: re-authenticate the feed connection in Xero's bank account settings — do not delete the connection. If re-authentication fails twice, check whether the bank changed its login page (banks do this silently a few times a year), then escalate to support with the bank name, feed type, last successful import date, and the exact error text.

Triage 2: The reconciliation that won't balance

The difference is small, the cause is invisible, and you've stared at it for an hour. Export the unreconciled lines and the account's transaction list, anonymize, and prompt:



COPY-PASTE PROMPT – reconciliation mismatch hunt: Help find why this bank account won't reconcile in Xero. Statement balance: [AMOUNT] at [DATE]. Xero balance: [AMOUNT] at [DATE]. Difference: [AMOUNT]. Here are the unreconciled transactions: [PASTE]. And here are transactions posted near the statement date: [PASTE]. Check systematically for: (1) transposed digits – amounts differing by a multiple of 9, (2) duplicate entries, (3) a transaction posted to the wrong date straddling the statement cutoff, (4) a bank fee or interest line never entered, (5) a transaction entered with the wrong sign. List suspects in order of likelihood with the exact amounts. Do not invent transactions.

The transposed-digit check is the killer feature — humans are terrible at spotting that 1,294 and 1,924 differ by a multiple of 9. AI does it instantly. This single prompt has probably saved more Friday afternoons than any other in this book.

Triage 3: Payroll errors before payday

Payroll mistakes are the highest-stakes errors in the book — real people, real money, real deadlines. The workflow here is verification, not diagnosis:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – pre-payroll verification: Verify this anonymized payroll run before submission. [NUMBER] employees. For each employee: [PASTE – hours or salary, pay rate, deductions, net pay]. Prior pay period figures for comparison: [PASTE]. Flag: (1) any net pay that changed more than [THRESHOLD, e.g. 10%] versus prior period without an obvious reason, (2) any deduction that disappeared or appeared versus prior period, (3) any hourly employee with round-number hours that look estimated rather than actual, (4) overtime hours that don't match the timesheet total I provide. Present as a check-before-submitting list. This is a review aid – final verification is mine. Timesheet totals: [PASTE]

Run this every pay period. It takes five minutes and it's the cheapest insurance your practice offers. Note the framing in the prompt: "final verification is mine." Say that to the client too. Payroll is where you never, ever let AI have the last word.

The triage log

Keep a running log — one page per incident: date, client, symptom, diagnosis, fix, time to resolve. After a quarter, prompt:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – triage pattern review: Review these anonymized support incidents from the last quarter: [PASTE LOG]. Identify: (1) the three most frequent failure types, (2) any client with a disproportionate share of incidents and the likely root cause (e.g. their bank's aggregator is unreliable), (3) one preventive action per pattern – a setting, a habit, or a client conversation that would stop it recurring.

That log becomes two assets: faster future triage (you've seen this before) and evidence for client conversations ("your bank's feed has broken four times this quarter — let's talk about switching the connection method or the bank").

Your same-day action: Start the triage log today with your last three support incidents, even from memory. Then run the reconciliation-mismatch prompt on the next stubborn difference instead of staring at it. Time both approaches. You'll never stare again.

CHAPTER 8**Advisory upsells — turning analysis into revenue**

Here's where the playbook pays for itself permanently. Everything so far saved you hours. This chapter converts those hours into the highest-margin work a practice can sell: advisory.

The uncomfortable math: compliance bookkeeping is price-shopped; advisory is not. Nobody switches accountants to save 10% on "someone who tells me which of my service lines to kill." But most practices never sell advisory because they're drowning in the mechanical work Chapters 3–7 just took off their plate.

The advisory ladder

Don't launch a "CFO service." Climb a ladder — each rung is a small, fixed-price offer built from work you're already doing:

Rung 1: The monthly insight call (30 minutes). You're already writing the variance narrative from Chapter 5. Offer the call as the narrated version: you walk through the numbers, they ask questions, you both leave with actions. Price it fixed, monthly. The prompt that prepares you:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – insight call prep: Prepare me for a 30-minute monthly insight call with a [BUSINESS TYPE] owner. Anonymized financials: [THIS MONTH VS PRIOR MONTH VS SAME MONTH LAST YEAR – revenue, margins, cash, receivables]. Produce: (1) the three numbers that matter most this month and why, in plain language, (2) two questions to ask the owner that will reveal what's really happening behind the numbers, (3) one recommendation I can make confidently from the data, and (4) one topic to explicitly NOT raise yet because the data is inconclusive. Mark anything requiring the owner's operational context with [ASK OWNER].

Rung 2: The quarterly business review. Ninety minutes, forward-looking. Cash forecast, project pipeline, hiring math. The prompt:

COPY-PASTE PROMPT – quarterly review pack: Build a quarterly business review pack for a [BUSINESS TYPE] owner. Anonymized data: [QUARTER P&L, CASH TREND 6 MONTHS, RECEIVABLES AGING, ANY PROJECT/JOB MARGIN DATA]. Produce: (1) quarter in review – three plain-language headlines, (2) cash runway at current burn with two scenarios (revenue flat vs. revenue down 15%), (3) the one cost line growing fastest and what it might mean, (4) three decisions the owner should make this quarter, phrased as recommendations with the data behind each, and (5) an explicit list of what this analysis cannot conclude from the available data. No invented figures. Flag tax or legal implications with [CPA/ATTORNEY VERIFIES].

Rung 3: The pricing and profitability project. One-time engagement: which services, products, or clients actually make money. Uses the Chapter 6 project-profitability workflow plus AI analysis. This is the rung that changes how a client runs their business — and the one they'll tell other business owners about.

Selling it without selling

Bookkeepers hate selling. Good — don't sell. *Notice.* The script for Rung 1, sent with the monthly financials:

COPY-PASTE — insight call offer (send as-is, fill brackets): Hi [NAME] — your [MONTH] numbers are attached, with the usual summary. One thing I noticed this month: [ONE GENUINE OBSERVATION FROM THE DATA, e.g. your labor cost as a share of revenue is the highest it's been all year]. I offer a 30-minute monthly call where we walk through what the numbers are actually saying and what to do about them — [PRICE]/month, no commitment. Want to try one next week?

[EXAMPLE] — why this works (illustrative): the observation is real, specific, and slightly uncomfortable — exactly the thing a business owner can't unsee. You're not pitching a service; you're demonstrating it in one sentence. The practices that fill advisory calendars do it with this email, monthly, to every client. Most clients say no for three months and yes in month four, right after the month the numbers turn ugly.

The advisory pricing rule

Price advisory fixed and separate from compliance. Never bundle it into the monthly bookkeeping fee "as a bonus" — bonuses get taken for granted and can't be raised. The ladder works because each rung has a price, a defined deliverable, and an easy yes. Rung 1 should be priced so the client barely thinks about it; Rung 3 should be priced like the business-changing project it is.

The compliance firewall. Advisory is analysis and recommendations. Tax positions, filing decisions, and legal interpretations belong to the CPA or attorney — say so in the engagement letter and say so on the call. "Here's what the numbers suggest; your CPA confirms the tax treatment before you act on it." That sentence protects you, respects the CPA, and — counterintuitively — makes clients trust your advice more, because they can see where your confidence ends.

What this does to your practice

Run the numbers for yourself: if Rung 1 converts even a quarter of your client base, that's recurring high-margin revenue built on work (the Chapter 5 narrative) you're already doing. The mechanical hours you reclaimed in Chapters 3–7 are the capacity; this chapter is what you spend it on. That's the full arc of the playbook: AI takes the throughput, you take the judgment, and the judgment is what clients pay a premium for.

Your same-day action: Pick your three best clients. Draft the insight-call offer email for each, with one genuine observation from their latest numbers. Send one. The ladder starts with a single rung.

CHAPTER 9**Your 30-day rollout plan**

You've read the playbook. Here's the order to install it — one week per phase, each building on the last. Don't try to do everything in week one. The practices that get value from AI install it like they'd install any system: in sequence, with each piece working before the next goes in.

Week 1: Foundation

- [] Set up the chatbot subscription with the practice profile from Chapter 2. Check data-retention settings.
- [] Write the four client-data privacy rules into your engagement letter template (have your attorney review the wording).
- [] Pick one client — ideally a straightforward one — as your pilot for every workflow in this book.
- [] Run the pre-close review prompt (Chapter 5) on last month's numbers for the pilot client.

End-of-week check: Can you paste anonymized data into the chatbot and get useful output in under five minutes? If yes, the foundation holds.

Week 2: Throughput

- [] Build the 48-hour onboarding kit (Chapter 3) and use it on your next new client — or retrofit it for a recent one.
- [] Run cleanup triage (Chapter 4) on your messiest client and re-quote or re-scope from the findings.
- [] Start the triage log (Chapter 7) with your last three incidents.
- [] Run the subscription tier audit (Chapter 6) on your three most expensive client Xero plans.

End-of-week check: Pick one number — hours spent on onboarding/cleanup/close this week versus a typical week. Write it down next to your Chapter 1 "before" picture.

Week 3: Insight

- [] Deliver one variance narrative (Chapter 5) with the [ASK OWNER] flags to a client. Note their reaction.
- [] Run the job-profitability review (Chapter 6) for one project-based client.
- [] Build one custom report (Chapter 6) answering a real question a client actually asked.
- [] Draft the insight-call offer email (Chapter 8) for your three best clients. Send one.

End-of-week check: Did any client reply to the narrative or the offer with a real business question? That's the advisory door opening.



Week 4: Systematize

- [] Turn the weekly checklists into templates: close checklist, missing-documents email, triage log entry.
- [] Review the triage log for patterns (Chapter 7) and implement one preventive fix.
- [] Decide your advisory ladder pricing (Chapter 8) and write it down — Rung 1, 2, and 3, fixed prices.
- [] Schedule a recurring monthly 30 minutes to re-run the tier audit and triage pattern review.

End-of-week check: Compare your Chapter 1 audit answers to today. The "after" picture. If onboarding is faster, cleanup is quotable, the close is calmer, and one advisory conversation started — the playbook worked.

What to do when something breaks

It will. A prompt will give a bad suggestion, a client will send data in a format nothing reads, a bank feed will break in a new and creative way. The rule for all of it: AI proposes, you dispose. The moment you feel yourself trusting the output instead of checking it, stop and re-read the privacy and verification rules in Chapter 2. The system works because the human stays in charge of every decision that matters.

Quick-reference: every prompt in this book

1. **Practice profile** (Ch. 2) — teaches the chatbot your practice, your limits, your privacy rules.
2. **Tailored document request list** (Ch. 3) — onboarding document list by business type.
3. **Chart-of-accounts mapping** (Ch. 3) — legacy accounts to standard Xero chart.
4. **Client welcome pack** (Ch. 3) — one-page how-we-work document.
5. **Kickoff call agenda** (Ch. 3) — 15-minute structured agenda.
6. **Onboarding check-in emails** (Ch. 3) — day 7/14/21 nudges.
7. **Cleanup triage** (Ch. 4) — severity rating, hour-range estimate, quote foundation.
8. **Categorization review** (Ch. 4) — batched transaction categorization with confidence ratings.
9. **Duplicate detection** (Ch. 4) — suspected duplicate pairs for review.
10. **Cleanup summary for client** (Ch. 4) — plain-language what-we-fixed page.
11. **Monthly close checklist** (Ch. 5) — generated from this month's actual state.
12. **Missing-documents email** (Ch. 5) — day-2-of-close nudge.
13. **Pre-close review** (Ch. 5) — second pair of eyes before sign-off.
14. **Monthly variance narrative** (Ch. 5) — "are we okay?" in plain language.
15. **Foreign-currency exposure summary** (Ch. 6) — multi-currency clarity without the tier.
16. **Job profitability review** (Ch. 6) — project margins from tracking categories.
17. **Custom report builder** (Ch. 6) — answers the question Xero's reports can't.
18. **Subscription tier audit** (Ch. 6) — stay, downgrade, or upgrade, with the math.
19. **Bank feed diagnosis** (Ch. 7) — symptoms to likely causes, in order, with what-not-to-do.
20. **Reconciliation mismatch hunt** (Ch. 7) — systematic difference-finding.
21. **Pre-payroll verification** (Ch. 7) — check-before-submitting list.
22. **Triage pattern review** (Ch. 7) — quarterly incident analysis and prevention.
23. **Insight call prep** (Ch. 8) — 30-minute advisory call preparation.
24. **Quarterly review pack** (Ch. 8) — forward-looking 90-minute review.
25. **Insight call offer** (Ch. 8) — the one-sentence email that fills advisory calendars.



Thank you

If this playbook saves you ten hours a month, spend two of them calling a client just to talk about their business. The AI handles the throughput now. The relationships were always the job.

If something in this book didn't work for your practice, or you found a better prompt, I'd genuinely like to hear about it — every playbook in this series gets better when practitioners share what actually happened. You'll find contact details on the SkillForge AI site.

Now close this file and go run the Week 1 checklist. The first five minutes are the hardest.

— Bill